SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #31 · SUCCESS, STATUS AND MONEY

"My worth depends on my success."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Praise for good grades, wins, promotions, and paychecks teaches that we are loved for what we achieve. In competitive cultures, success becomes the scorecard of worth, and failure feels like personal defect. Even in church, the successful may be applauded most.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast." Jesus asks, "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world, yet forfeit his soul?" "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made." "God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us." Our worth was established before we achieved anything. Work is good, and diligence matters, but they are expressions of life, not its foundation.

> *"For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast"* (Ephesians 2:8–9).

Also see

> "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world, yet forfeit his soul?" (Mark 8:36).

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

> "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8).

> "Therefore, my beloved brothers, be steadfast and immovable. Always excel in the work of the Lord, because you know that your labor in the Lord is not in vain" (1 Corinthians 15:58).

Common self-statements

- I am what I achieve.
- If I stop succeeding, I am nothing.
- My value goes up and down with results.
- I have to keep proving myself.
- Failure means I am a failure.
- I have to win to matter.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either a success or a failure.
- Labeling: Calling myself a failure after a setback.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling worthless after a loss and concluding that I am.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must always succeed.

Challenging questions

- When did I first learn that success earns love?
- Who loves me whether I succeed or not?

- What would I be if I lost my title, income, or achievements?
- What does Scripture say about the basis of my worth?
- What do I do when I fail?
- What is one thing I can enjoy this week without measuring it?

Truth summary

> My worth does not rise and fall with my success. I am loved by God and saved by grace. I can work hard and enjoy the fruit, while resting in a worth that was given and cannot be taken.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride
- Salvation
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "My worth depends on my success"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My worth depends on my success." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me success earns worth?
- ☐ Who loves me regardless?
- ☐ What would I be without my achievements?
- ☐ What does Scripture say?
- ☐ What do I do when I fail?
- ☐ What can I enjoy without measuring?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am saved by grace, not works.
- ☐ My worth was given before I achieved.
- ☐ What matters is my soul.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ My labor in the Lord is not in vain.
- ☐ I am loved when I fail.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ephesians 2:8–9
  "For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast."
- ☐ Mark 8:36
  "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world, yet forfeit his soul?"
- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Worth beyond results: Each week, note one thing you did without needing it to prove anything.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ephesians 2:8–9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am saved by grace, so my worth does not depend on success.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Trace the lesson. Write who taught you that success earns worth.
- [ ] Write who you are without it. List five things true of you apart from achievements.
- [ ] Fail on purpose, small. Try something you might not be good at.
- [ ] Read Ephesians 2:8–9. Say it each morning.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My worth depends on my success": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth beyond results
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My worth depends on my success.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I have measured myself by success. Thank You that You saved me by grace. Free me to work with joy and rest in the worth You have given. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #32 · SUCCESS, STATUS AND MONEY

“If I don't have enough money, I'm a failure.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

In a culture that equates money with competence, financial struggle can feel like personal failure. Layoffs, illness, caregiving, family obligations, and rising costs create shortfalls that have nothing to do with character, yet shame follows.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound… to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength.” Jesus said, “One’s life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.” The psalmist says, “Better is the little of the righteous than the abundance of many who are wicked.” James asks, “Has not God chosen the poor of this world to be rich in faith?” Jesus Himself was born into modest means. Financial shortfall is a circumstance to address, not a verdict on who you are.

> *“I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength”* (Philippians 4:12–13).

Also see

> “And He said to them, ‘Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one’s life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.’” (Luke 12:15).

> “Better is the little of the righteous than the abundance of many who are wicked” (Psalm 37:16).

> “Listen, my beloved brothers: Has not God chosen the poor of this world to be rich in faith and to inherit the kingdom He promised those who love Him?” (James 2:5).

> “The rich and the poor have this in common: The LORD is Maker of them all” (Proverbs 22:2).

Common self-statements

- If I had been smarter, I would have more.
- Money problems prove I am a failure.
- Everyone else is doing better.
- I should be further ahead.
- I am a disappointment to my family.
- I cannot hold my head up.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself a failure instead of describing a shortfall.
- Personalization: Blaming myself for circumstances beyond my control.
- Social comparison: Measuring myself against others’ finances.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either financially secure or a failure.

Challenging questions

- What contributed to my financial situation that was outside my control?
- What would I tell a friend in the same position?
- What do I value that has nothing to do with money?
- What practical steps could improve things?
- What does Scripture say about money and worth?
- Who could help me with a plan?

Truth summary

> Money does not measure my worth or my character. I can face my finances honestly, take practical steps, and know that God's grace is not tied to my bank balance.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Poverty
- Money
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Trust
- Hardship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Money/Riches
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "If I don't have enough money, I'm a failure"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I don't have enough money, I'm a failure." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What was outside my control?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What do I value besides money?
- ☐ What practical step can I take?
- ☐ What does Scripture say?
- ☐ Who can help?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My life is not the abundance of my possessions.
- ☐ I can learn contentment in plenty and in need.
- ☐ God chose the poor to be rich in faith.
- ☐ Circumstances are not a verdict.
- ☐ I can take practical steps.
- ☐ I can ask for help.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Philippians 4:12–13**
  "I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."
- ☐ **Luke 12:15**
  "And He said to them, 'Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.'"
- ☐ **James 2:5**
  "Listen, my beloved brothers: Has not God chosen the poor of this world to be rich in faith and to inherit the kingdom He promised those who love Him?"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Worth and a plan: Each week, note one step in your plan and one truth about your worth.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Philippians 4:12–13 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Poverty" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write the facts. List income, expenses, and obligations without judgment.
- ☐ Name outside factors. Write what contributed that was not your fault.
- ☐ Make one change. Choose one practical step.
- ☐ Ask for help. Talk to a trusted advisor, church benevolence team, or nonprofit counselor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I don't have enough money, I'm a failure": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth and a plan
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I don't have enough money, I'm a failure.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, money is tight and shame is heavy. Remind me that my worth is not my balance. Give me wisdom for practical steps and peace in the meantime. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #33 · SUCCESS, STATUS AND MONEY

"Money and things will make me happy."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

We are surrounded by messages that the right income and possessions deliver contentment. Seeing the relief money brings in a crisis reinforces it. The pursuit can take over life and relationships, and each level reached shows another one to chase.

What Scripture teaches

Solomon writes, "He who loves money is never satisfied by money, and he who loves wealth is never satisfied by income. This too is futile." Jesus said, "Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth… For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also." He asks, "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world, yet forfeit his soul?" Paul tells the rich "not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God, who richly provides all things for us to enjoy." God is not against enjoying good things. He warns that they cannot carry the weight of our hearts.

> *"He who loves money is never satisfied by money, and he who loves wealth is never satisfied by income. This too is futile"* (Ecclesiastes 5:10).

Also see

> "Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moth and rust do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also" (Matthew 6:19–21).

> "Instruct those who are rich in the present age not to be conceited and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God, who richly provides all things for us to enjoy. Instruct them to do good, to be rich in good works, and to be generous and ready to share, treasuring up for themselves a firm foundation for the future, so that they may take hold of that which is truly life" (1 Timothy 6:17–19).

> "And He said to them, 'Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.'" (Luke 12:15).

> "What does it profit a man to gain the whole world, yet forfeit his soul?" (Mark 8:36).

Common self-statements

- I will be happy when I earn more.
- More money would fix everything.
- The next raise will do it.
- Things make life good.
- I need more to feel secure.
- If I could just afford that, I would be content.

Common logical errors

- Magical thinking: Believing that more money guarantees happiness.
- Postponement: Delaying contentment until later.
- Social comparison: Chasing what others have.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling wanting and concluding it must be filled by money.

Challenging questions

- What have I hoped money would give me?
- When have I had more and been no happier?
- What gives me lasting joy that is not for sale?
- Where is my treasure, and where is my heart?
- What does Scripture say about the limits of wealth?
- What is one way to enjoy what I have and share it?

Truth summary

> Money is a useful tool and a poor master. It cannot give lasting happiness. My hope is in God, who richly provides things to enjoy. I can use money wisely, enjoy it, and share it.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Riches, Beware of
- Riches, True
- Greedy/Stingy
- Money
- Joy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Money/Riches
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Forever — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

How Great Thou Art — Jordan Smith
This classic hymn connects God's greatness, Christ's sacrifice, and future hope.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Money and things will make me happy"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Money and things will make me happy." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I hope money gives?
- ☐ When did more not satisfy?
- ☐ What joy is free?
- ☐ Where is my treasure?
- ☐ What is enough?
- ☐ What can I give?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Money cannot satisfy.
- ☐ My treasure should be in heaven.
- ☐ Hope belongs in God, not wealth.
- ☐ God provides things to enjoy.
- ☐ Generosity brings joy.
- ☐ I can be content with enough.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Ecclesiastes 5:10**
  "He who loves money is never satisfied by money, and he who loves wealth is never satisfied by income. This too is futile."
- ☐ **Matthew 6:19–21**
  "Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moth and rust do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also."
- ☐ **1 Timothy 6:17–19**
  "Instruct those who are rich in the present age not to be conceited and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God, who richly provides all things for us to enjoy. Instruct them to do good, to be rich in good works, and to be generous and ready to share, treasuring up for themselves a firm foundation for the future, so that they may take hold of that which is truly life."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Lasting joy: Each week, note one source of joy that did not cost money.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ecclesiastes 5:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "My treasure is in heaven, so money will not decide my happiness.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Riches, Beware of" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Examine the promise. Write what you hope more money will give.
- ☐ List free joys. Write ten sources of joy that do not cost money.
- ☐ Give something. Share money or time with someone in need.
- ☐ Set an enough. Define a level of income or spending that is enough.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Money and things will make me happy": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Lasting joy
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Money and things will make me happy.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have looked to money for happiness. Teach me to use it wisely, to enjoy Your gifts, and to find my joy in You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #34 · SUCCESS, STATUS AND MONEY

“I must keep up with everyone around me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Neighborhood, church, school, workplace, and family can set an unspoken pace: the right house, car, vacation, school, wardrobe. Falling behind feels like being judged. Many carry debt, stress, and exhaustion just to avoid standing out.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another,” and “Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves.” “Live in harmony with one another. Do not be proud, but enjoy the company of the lowly.” Solomon says, “A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones.” Hebrews urges, “let us run with endurance the race set out for us,” which is our own race, not someone else’s. Racing the neighbors is a poor use of the life God has given.

> *“Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another”* (Galatians 5:26).

Also see

> “Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves” (Philippians 2:3).

> “Live in harmony with one another. Do not be proud, but enjoy the company of the lowly. Do not be conceited” (Romans 12:16).

> “A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones” (Proverbs 14:30).

> “Therefore, since we are surrounded by such a great cloud of witnesses, let us throw off every encumbrance and the sin that so easily entangles, and let us run with endurance the race set out for us” (Hebrews 12:1).

Common self-statements

- Everyone else has more.
- If I do not keep up, I will be judged.
- I have to match my neighbors.
- I cannot let my family fall behind.
- Slowing down is losing.
- What will people think?

Common logical errors

- Social comparison: Measuring my life by those around me.
- Mind reading: Assuming others judge my standard of living.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should match others.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining disgrace if I do not keep up.

Challenging questions

- Who am I trying to keep up with, and why?
- What is the cost of keeping up in money, time, and peace?
- What would my life look like if I ran my own race?

- What do I truly value, and does my spending match?
- What does Scripture say about envy and humility?
- What is one thing I can stop doing to keep up?

Truth summary

> I am not called to race my neighbors. I can run my own race with endurance, live within my means, and value people over appearances. Peace is worth more than keeping up.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Envy/Jealousy
- Worldly
- Pride
- Dissatisfaction
- Humility

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Pride
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must keep up with everyone around me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must keep up with everyone around me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whom am I keeping up with?
- ☐ What does it cost?
- ☐ What are my values?
- ☐ What can I drop?
- ☐ What would my own race look like?
- ☐ What would peace feel like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I run my own race.
- ☐ Envy rots; a tranquil heart gives life.
- ☐ Humility considers others.
- ☐ I can enjoy simple things.
- ☐ Peace is worth more than status.
- ☐ I do not have to match anyone.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Galatians 5:26
  "Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another."
- ☐ Philippians 2:3
  "Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves."
- ☐ Hebrews 12:1
  "Therefore, since we are surrounded by such a great cloud of witnesses, let us throw off every encumbrance and the sin that so easily entangles, and let us run with endurance the race set out for us."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] My own race: Each week, note one thing you chose for your values, not for appearances.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Hebrews 12:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I will run with endurance the race set out for me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Envy/Jealousy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the group. Write who you feel you must keep up with.
- [ ] Count the cost. List what it costs in money, time, and peace.
- [ ] Drop one thing. Stop one expense or activity done for show.
- [ ] Define your values. Write three things that matter most.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must keep up with everyone around me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	My own race
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must keep up with everyone around me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I am tired of keeping up. Help me run my own race, value what You value, and find peace in enough. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #35 · SUCCESS, STATUS AND MONEY

“Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Sports, school, business, and even church ministries can teach that only winners matter. Parents who cheer wins and sulk over losses, coaches who shame mistakes, and a culture that celebrates champions make losing feel like disgrace. Fear of losing can make us avoid trying.

What Scripture teaches

Paul uses the race as a picture: “Run in such a way as to take the prize,” and at the end of his life, “I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith.” Notice he does not say, “I won every race.” Solomon observes, “The race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong… For time and chance happen to all.” Paul says, “In all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us.” The psalmist says, “It is God who judges; He brings down one and exalts another.” Faithfulness, not victory, is the measure God gives.

> *“I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith”* (2 Timothy 4:7).

Also see

> “Do you not know that in a race all the runners run, but only one receives the prize? Run in such a way as to take the prize. Everyone who competes in the games trains with strict discipline. They do it for a crown that is perishable, but we do it for a crown that is imperishable” (1 Corinthians 9:24–25).

> “I saw something else under the sun: The race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong; neither is the bread to the wise, nor the wealth to the intelligent, nor the favor to the skillful. For time and chance happen to all” (Ecclesiastes 9:11).

> “No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us” (Romans 8:37).

> “For exaltation comes neither from east nor west, nor out of the desert, but it is God who judges; He brings down one and exalts another” (Psalm 75:6–7).

Common self-statements

- If I lose, I am a loser.
- Second place is failure.
- I have to win to be valued.
- I cannot stand losing.
- Winners matter and losers do not.
- I would rather not try than lose.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing outcomes as win or total loss.
- Labeling: Calling myself a loser.
- Perfectionism: Demanding victory every time.
- Catastrophizing: Treating a loss as ruin.

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn that only winning counts?
- What have I learned from my losses?
- Who do I admire, and is it for winning or for character?
- What does faithfulness look like in my situation?
- What would I attempt if losing were not a disaster?
- What does God say about worth apart from outcomes?

Truth summary

> My worth does not depend on winning. Faithfulness, effort, and character matter most, and God sees them. I can compete with joy, lose with grace, and be more than a conqueror through Christ's love.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Strength
- Faith

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

More Than Conquerors — Steven Curtis Chapman
Christ's saving work answers condemnation, shame, and fear of separation from God.

Grace Wins — Matthew West
Grace offers a new beginning rather than defining a person by failure.

Greater — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
This classic gospel hymn celebrates Christ's rescue and the hope of life with Him.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me only wins count?
- ☐ What have I learned from losing?
- ☐ Whom do I admire?
- ☐ What is faithfulness?
- ☐ What would I try?
- ☐ What does God say?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can finish the race and keep the faith.
- ☐ Time and chance happen to all.
- ☐ I am more than a conqueror through Christ.
- ☐ God judges, not the scoreboard.
- ☐ Losing teaches.
- ☐ I can try without fear.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Timothy 4:7
  "I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith."
- ☐ Romans 8:37
  "No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us."
- ☐ Ecclesiastes 9:11
  "I saw something else under the sun: The race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong; neither is the bread to the wise, nor the wealth to the intelligent, nor the favor to the skillful. For time and chance happen to all."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Faithful, not flawless: Each week, note one effort made and one lesson from a loss.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, 2 Timothy 4:7 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can finish the race and keep the faith, win or lose.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Pride" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Trace the message. Write who taught you that only winning counts.
- ☐ Debrief a loss. Write three lessons from a recent loss.
- ☐ Try something new. Do something you might not win.
- ☐ Encourage a loser. Cheer for someone who tried and lost.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Faithful, not flawless
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Winning is everything, and losing means I'm nothing.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I fear losing. Teach me that faithfulness matters more than winning, and help me compete with joy and lose with grace, knowing Your love does not change. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.